

Session 13: The Different “Encyclopedias” of Authors and Readers

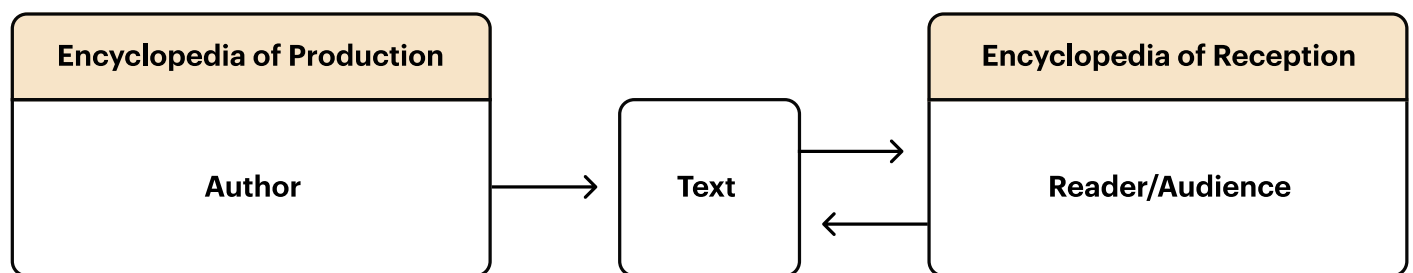
Key Takeaways

- Learning to read the Hebrew Bible well requires an awareness of our personal “encyclopedias of reception” and a discovery of the “encyclopedias of production” assumed by the biblical authors as they communicate.
- The Hebrew Bible is carefully crafted literature with every word placed intentionally to convey a specific message.
- Learning to read the Hebrew Bible requires studying the specific conventions and ways the biblical authors wrote narrative, poetry, and discourse.

Two Revolutionary Ideas About the Hebrew Bible

1. The Old Testament is an ancient text.
2. A text is an act of intentional literary communication.

Theory of Textual Communication



Textual Communication. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Where is meaning located? At first, it is in the mind of an author. But in the case of ancient authors, we no longer have access to their minds apart from the text. The text is the literary embodiment of an author’s purposed communication.

“Encyclopedia of Production” and “Encyclopedia of Reception”

Our “encyclopedia” is the mental storehouse of words, ideas, images, and stories that we gather and store in our memories from our first waking moments. Every text we read will be interpreted and understood in light of

our current operating encyclopedia. Authors have their encyclopedias from which they produce texts, and readers have encyclopedias they use to process and understand texts.

The model reader who wants to understand an author on their own terms will adapt their encyclopedia of reception by learning about the author's encyclopedia of production.

For more on this distinction between the encyclopedia of production and encyclopedia of reception, see Stefan Alkier, *Reading the Bible Intertextually* (pages 3-21).

Overcoming Challenges of Differing Encyclopedias

One of the great challenges in reading the Bible is that it takes work to become aware of our own modern encyclopedias of reception that we (unknowingly) impose upon the biblical author. This shows up when we, for example, impose modern cosmology onto the ancient cosmology of Genesis 1, or when we attribute much later doctrinal ideas/debates to the biblical authors (e.g., debates about Calvinism versus Arminianism, divine sovereignty and human free will, etc.).

Another significant challenge is that it takes effort to discover the encyclopedia of production assumed by the author as they communicate. We can increase our understanding of the author's encyclopedia by learning something about Hebrew, ancient Near Eastern worldviews, and ancient Israelite history and culture. The biblical authors also assume a high degree of familiarity with the TaNaK because it was first produced and read within a small community that was immersed in its textual world. It is a highly hyperlinked set of texts, whose puzzles and ambiguities become more clear after repeated re-reading over a lifetime.

Literature and Poetics

What is literature? Literature is a form of written communication through which an author conveys a “what” (the message) through a carefully and intentionally crafted “how” (an artistically formed/shaped literary work).

“A text-focused approach sets out to understand not the realities behind the text, but the text itself as a pattern of meaning and effect. What does this piece of language ... signify in context? What are the rules governing the transaction between the storyteller or poet and the reader? ... What image of a world does the narrative project? Why does it unfold the action in this particular order and from this particular viewpoint? ... How does the work hang together? In what relationship does each part stand to the whole? To pursue this line of questioning is to make sense of the work as an act of communication, always goal-directed on the writer's part and always requiring interpretive activity on the addressee's. The author wields certain linguistic and literary tools with an eye to certain effects on the reader, while the reader infers a coherent message from the signals, and it is the text itself that mediates between these two, embodying the author's intent and guiding the reader's response.”

Sternberg, Meir (1987). [*The Poetics of Biblical Narrative: Ideological Literature and the Drama of Reading*](#). Indiana University Press. 15.

Poetics (noun) is the unique set of literary techniques, conventions, and strategies employed by the biblical authors. Biblical narrative, poetry, and discourse all have a particular stylistic profile that is both similar to and different from other ancient Near Eastern literature.

"A coherent reading of any work of art, whatever the medium, requires some detailed awareness of the grid of conventions upon which and against which this particular work operates. Usually, these are elaborate sets of tacit agreements between artist and audience that create the enabling context in which the complex communication of art occurs. Through our awareness of convention we can recognize significant or simply pleasing patterns of repetition, symmetry, or contrast; we can detect subtle cues and clues as to the meaning of the work; we can spot what is innovative and what is traditional at each part of the artistic creation. ... One of the chief difficulties modern readers have in perceiving the artistry in biblical narrative is precisely that we have lost most of the keys to the conventions out of which these texts were shaped."

Alter, Robert (2011). [*The Art of Biblical Narrative*](#). Basic Books. 47.

Reflection Question

How would you respond to someone who says, "I don't need to understand the ancient conventions of the author because I think God will speak to me through the text even though I don't understand the ancient context"?